New MIT Educational Counselor Training 2026

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Admissions Officer



Why We Interview

Interviews Serve Three Main Purposes:

- **Humanizing MIT** → Showcasing MIT's positive aspects and clarifying misconceptions
- **Gathering valuable information** → Providing the admissions team with insights into the applicant's personal qualities, context, and match with MIT
- **Offering guidance** → giving students a more personal, in-depth understanding of MIT







What We're Looking for in Applicants

What we look for:

https://mitadmissions.org/apply/process/what-we-look-for/

- Mission match
- Collaboration
- Initiative
- Risk-Taking
- Hands-on Creativity
- Curiosity
- Priority Balance
- Trail blazers

Who Can Be an EC

ECs are MIT alums

Conflicts of interest will affect eligibility

- ECs whose **work involves college admissions** cannot interview applicants while employed in that field. **Examples include** college admissions officers, school guidance counselors, independent college counselors, and college preparation consultants.

Conflicts can restrict an EC

- An EC who's the **immediate family member of a current college applicant or lives in the same household as a current college applicant** cannot interview any applicants the year their student applies. **Regardless of whether the applicant applying to MIT or not.**
- **Secondary institution employees** cannot interview students in their school district.
- ECs may **not represent another undergraduate institution** in the same cycle.

Key Dates and Deadlines (EA)

- June to September: recruiting
- September: training
- Late September to early November: assigning applicants to ECs
- October 21: QuestBridge (https://mitadmissions.org/apply/firstyear/questbridge/) Finalist announced
- November 1st: EA application deadline
- Mid-November: QuestBridge Interview reports due
- Mid-to Later November: EA Interview reports due
- December 1: QuestBridge Match results revealed
- Mid-December: EA decisions released

Key Dates and Deadlines (RA)

- Late December to early January: assigning applicants to ECs
- early January: RA application deadline
- Mid February: RA Interview reports due
- Mid March: RA decisions released

The EC Portal

- Login into the EC Portal using MIT Alumni account (https://apply.mitadmissions.org/portal/ecportal?tab=home)
- Sign the **Best Practices Agreement** *(required first login each year)*
  - Mostly shared with the public (https://mitadmissions.org/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/MIT-Interview-Expectations.pdf)
- Set your status to **"Active"** on the **My Info** tab (or **Inactive** with a reason)
- Choose your **interview limit** on the **My Info** tab.
  - Default: 4 interviews for Early Action (EA), 5 for Regular Action (RA)
  - For new ECs, we **recommend** 3 interviews for EA and 4 for RA
  - You can adjust the limits
  - On average each EC spends **about 3 hours** to schedule, conduct the interview, and submit a report.

apply.mitadmissions.org/portal/ecportal?cmd=best_practices

MIT Admissions

MIT Educational Council Statement of Best Practices

Alumni volunteers in the Educational Counselor (EC) program agree to abide by these general practices and principles:

1. Eligibility
    a. All Educational Counselors must be MIT alums of either undergraduate or graduate programs
    b. Conflicts of interest, real or perceived, will inform the representative's eligibility. Such conflicts include:
        i. ECs whose work relates to college admissions cannot interview applicants while employed in that field. Examples include college admissions officers, school guidance counselors, independent college counselors, and college preparation consultants.
        ii. Secondary institution employees cannot interview students in their school district.
        iii. An EC who is the immediate family member of a current college applicant or lives in the same household as a current college applicant cannot interview any applicants the year their student applies, regardless of whether the applicant is applying to MIT or not.
    c. An EC may not represent more than one undergraduate institution in the same admissions cycle.
2. Expectations for EC and Applicant Interactions
    a. ECs will strive to create a mutually respectful environment and interaction.
    b. ECs will ensure that interactions occur in a safe, accessible, and neutral location. Interviews cannot take place in an EC's home or workplace.
    c. ECs will ensure interviews take place at a time that is agreed upon by both parties that respect the volunteer's and the student's commitments to school, work, activities, and family obligations.
    d. ECs will treat all information provided by MIT or the applicant as confidential, including the name of the applicant and the occurrence of the interview. No information regarding any part of the interview process should be shared. For example, ECs should not post on social media about interviews they conducted or admissions statistics.
    e. ECs will keep all information about MIT's admissions and interview procedures confidential, including the rating system and the overflow assignment process.
    f. ECs should delete notes and reports about applicants from their personal devices after submitting them on the portal.
    g. ECs will not interview applicants with whom there is an existing personal, familial, or professional connection. If assigned to an applicant the EC already knows, the EC should report to their RC or the EC office so the applicant can be reassigned.
    h. ECs will not request that applicants provide specific materials (i.e. transcript, application, essays, resume, questionnaire) to their interviewer.
    i. ECs will not give students tests, quizzes, logic puzzles, brainteasers or involved brainstorming topics.
    j. ECs should not create any impressions or expectations, positive or negative, about the student's probability of admission.
    k. ECs will not initiate conversations that may make a candidate uncomfortable or overly personal, regarding the candidate or the interviewer.
    l. ECs will use appropriate language.
    m. ECs will not ask the student where else they are applying.
    n. ECs will not record the interview.
3. MIT Policies for Educational Counselors
    a. As a representative of the Institute, you are expected to comply with MIT's policies prohibiting discrimination and harassment. We ask that you review MIT's policy on nondiscrimination and harassment.

The Interview Process

https://apply.mitadmissions.org/portal/ecportal?tab=home



Yi, Welcome to the Educational Counselor (EC) Portal

Thank you for being a part of the Educational Council. The work you do plays a crucial role in MIT's ability to attract and enroll the absolute best students in the world. This private site offers resources and tools to help you make the most of your volunteer experience.

All ECs, please keep the information on this website (including the rating system) and information about applicants confidential.

All ECs, please go to the My Info Tab above and EITHER (1) make your status Active using the dropdown followed by the SUBMIT button, OR (2) SELECT Inactive/Temporarily Inactive and include a short reason in the text box. The reason will be viewable to the Regional Chair and/or Vice-Chair (RC/VC) and the Educational Council Office. If you select Retired, please email ecquestions@mit.edu so we may remove you from future emails.

Next, please select the Resources Tab and review the Interview Guide, Interview FAQ, EC Portal Guide, General EC Calendar, and Sample Interview Invitation email template. We've provided a copy of the 2022 EC Reunion Workshop slides that you may find helpful to review before speaking with applicants. The Reunion Workshop slides include admissions statistics for the Class of 2025 and 2026 and EC interview statistics. We've also included links to recorded Zoom training sessions for new ECs, Grad Alumni ECs, and Tips for Interviewing and Writing Reports.

If you have any questions or concerns regarding your applicant assignments, contact your RC/VC (contact info on the right side of this page). For all other inquiries, please don't hesitate to contact our office at ecquestions@mit.edu.

Contact Information

RC

Christopher Yang - RC Cambridge
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MIT Educational Council Office

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The EC Portal Resources Tab

- How to use the EC Portal Guide
- Sample Reports
- Training Materials
- General Interview cycle calendar
- Sample email to students to set up interview

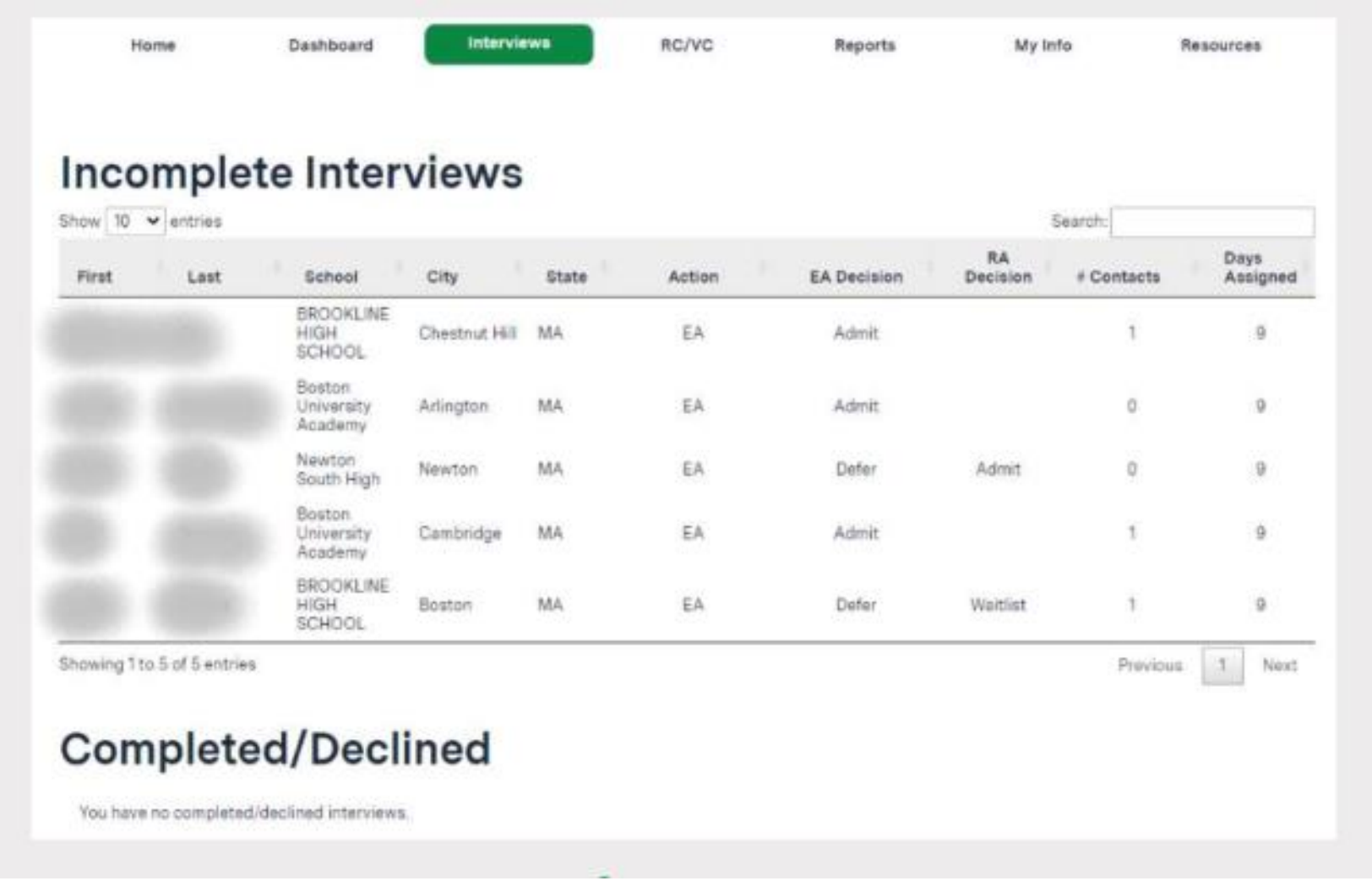
Guard Confidential Information

- Interview process (e.g., interview assignment process, existence of overflow)
- Specific admissions statistics (e.g., number admitted, which HS has admitted students)
- Interview information (e.g., interviewed students from specific HS)
- Platforms include reddit, Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, Linkedin, etc.

Applicant Assignments

- You'll receive an **automatic email** when an applicant is assigned to you.
  - EA assignments: mostly late September to early November
  - RA assignments: mostly late December to early January
  - Assigned by HS, region, RC/VC manually, or EC Office manually
  - May be reassigned by RC/VC or EC Office
- **Avoid conflicts of interest.** If you're assigned to an applicant you know, contact your **Regional Chairperson (RC)/Vice Chairperson (VC),** or the **EC Office** for reassignment.

Applicant Assignments

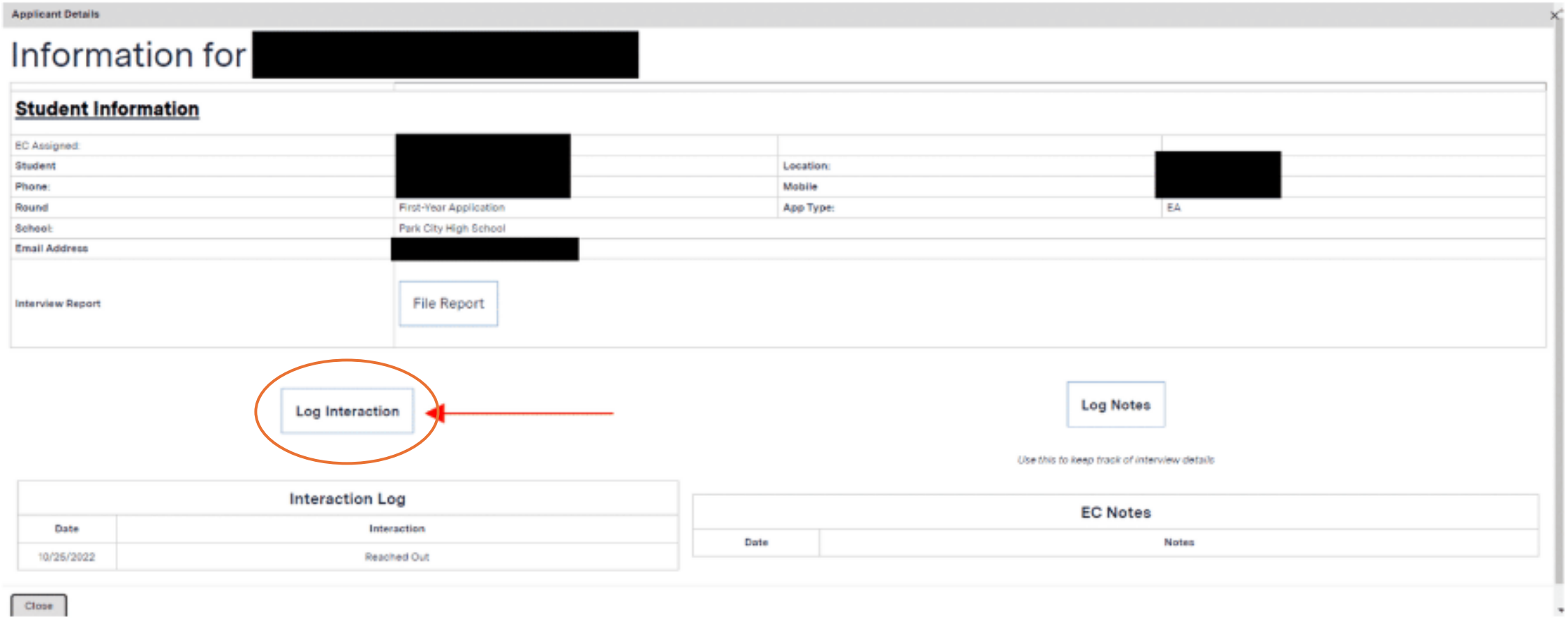


Overflow

Want to interview **outside** of your region?

- Opt in as an **Overflow Interviewer** on the **My Info tab**
- You can select applicants from Overflow Tab
- Assign yourself using dropdown next to the student's name
- Be mindful of time zone differences
- **Avoid conflicts of interest and only take applicants as your time permits**

Logging Interactions



Logging Interactions

Please log all interactions in the portal to keep RC, VC and EC office up to date on the status of the interview.

- **Reach Out** – log when you first reach out to the applicant
- **Reached Out 2** – log if you reach out second time. ECs are only expected to reach out to applicants up to **two times**
- **Scheduled interview** – log when you agree on a time with the student
- **Conducted** – log when the interview is done
- **No Response** – log if the applicant hasn't responded **after two attempts**
- **Student Refused** – log if the student **declines** the interview after contact

Scheduling the Interview

- The assigned applicant email notification includes a **template email** to contact the applicant (also found on **Resources Tab)**
- **Format:**
  - In-Person: **held in a public place** and target commute of 30 minutes or less each way
  - Virtual: agree on platform (no recording)
- **Timing:**
  - Offer a **few different time options** and schedule a time that works for both of you.
  - Please **reach out promptly** after being assigned.
  - Tell RC or VC if applicants need to be reassigned.
- **Reaching Out:**
  - Attempt to reach the applicant **twice**
  - If the applicant does not reply to your emails, you can send them a **text message**. This is an optional step but can get more replies than emails

Conducting the Interview

- Keep it **conversational**. Learn about the student and answer their questions about MIT.
- Aim for about **1 hour** (30 minutes to several hours is okay depending on flow of conversation).
- Create a positive, respectful, and friendly environment.

Interview Tips



Do

- Review training materials before your interview.
- Meet in a **public place** like a coffee shop or library **(not your home or workplace)**.
- Help the student feel comfortable. Let them know it's **a two-way** conversation.
- **Encourage** them to ask questions.
- Let the student do most of the talking.
- Speak in English
- Keep the conversation appropriate, use respectful language and stay on appropriate topics
- **Take notes** to help with writing our report late
- **Keep information confidential**

Interview Don’ts



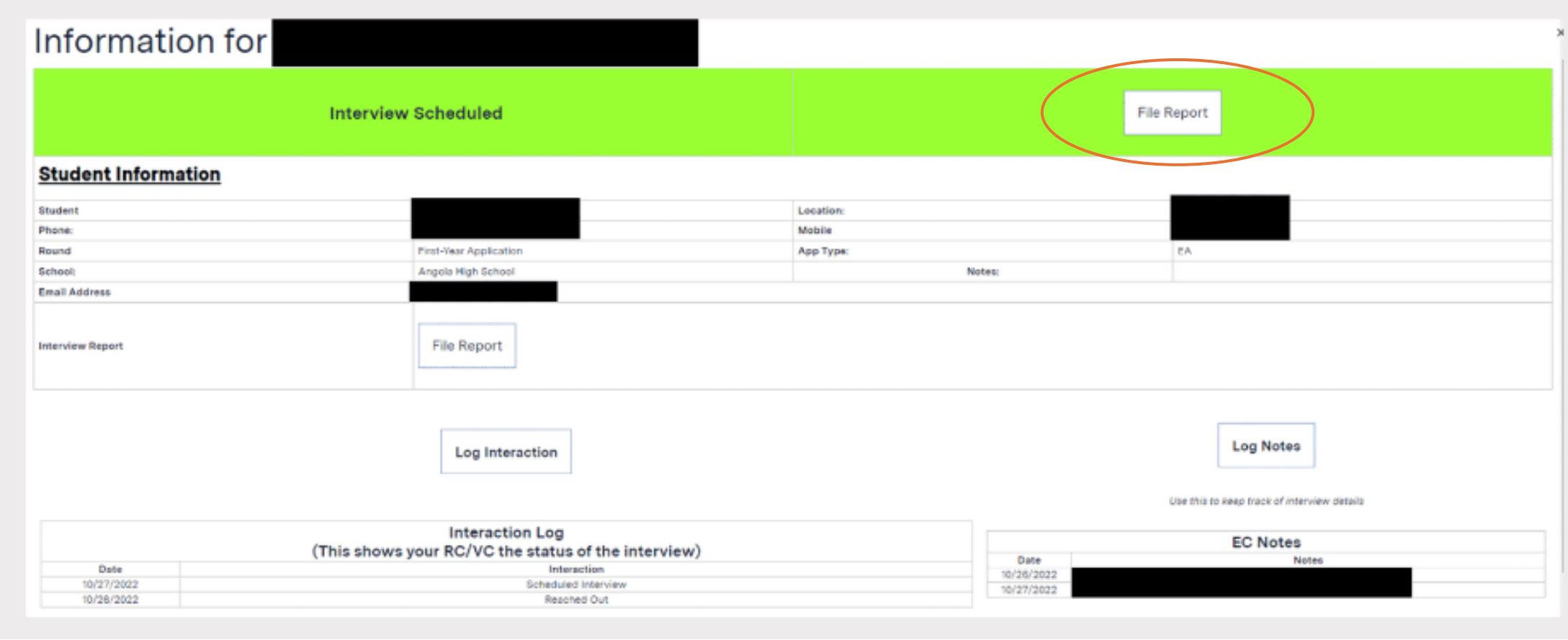
Don’t

- Research the student before the interview **(let your impressions come from the conversation)**
- Ask for documents like transcripts, essays, resume, or research
- Give tests or puzzles **(this is a conversation, not a quiz)**.
- Give opinions or comments on their chances of admission
- Ask where else they are applying or whether MIT is their top choice. Keep focus on MIT **(don’t compare colleges)**
- Record the interview
- **Bring up personal topics** like religion, race, or sexual orientation, politics, income, or residency status. If the student brings these up on their own, it’s okay to listen but be **respectful and sensitive**.

General Approach to the Interview

- Ask a broad question, then follow up to go deeper. You can repeat this process for projects, courses, activities, and any other questions you ask.
- First, ask: "*Tell me about a [project/course/person/activity] that is important to you.*"
- Then ask follow up questions depending on responses:
  - *Why did you choose this [xyz]?*
  - *What did you enjoy about it?*
  - *What was challenging?*
  - *What role did you play?*
  - *How would you do it differently if you did the project again?*

Interview Report



Information for [redacted]

Interview Scheduled

File Report

Student Information

Student	[redacted]	Location:	[redacted]
Phone:		Mobile	
Round	First-Year Application	App Type:	EA
School:	Angola High School	Notes:	
Email Address	[redacted]		
Interview Report	File Report		

Log Interaction

Log Notes

Use this to keep track of interview details

Interaction Log
(This shows your RC/VC the status of the interview)

Date	Interaction
10/27/2022	Scheduled Interview
10/26/2022	Reached Out

EC Notes

Date	Notes
10/26/2022	[redacted]
10/27/2022	

Rating the Applicant

Category Ratings

Please rate the applicant's characteristics using the scale in the pull-down lists with 5 being the highest/best:

Engagement, Joyfulness and Love for Learning	Personal Qualities and Community Contributions	Match with MIT
We're looking for: • Initiative • Risk-taking • Intensity, curiosity, and excitement	**We're looking for:** • Collaborative and cooperative spirit • Active community members • The ability to prioritize balance	**We're looking for:** • Alignment with MIT's mission • Hands-on creativity
Questions to consider: • Does the student show curiosity, motivation, initiative, and passion? • Are they self-driven, take risks, and make the most of opportunities?	**Questions to consider:** • Would the student contribute to the MIT community? • Have they worked with others effectively in the past?	**Questions to consider:** • Is the student excited about MIT? • Do they enjoy solving problems in a hands-on way? • Do they use science and technology to help others?

Engagement and Joyfulness: ⌄ **Personal Qualities:** ⌄ **Match:** ⌄

Rating the Applicant

Overall Rating

Please select an overall rating for the applicant. Remember that many applicants are exceptional—use the full scale. A 3 or 4 is not a bad rating.

5 – Exceptional	One of the best students you've ever interviewed. A perfect fit. Brings up strong examples of everything we are looking for.
4 – Outstanding	Highly recommended for admission. In the top 10% of students you've interviewed. Meets most of the criteria.
3 – Solid	A strong, average MIT applicant. Would be a good admit. Meets some of what we are looking for.
2 – Below Average	Weaker than most MIT applicants. Meets few traits we are looking for.
1 – Not Recommended	You don't think this student is a good fit for MIT.

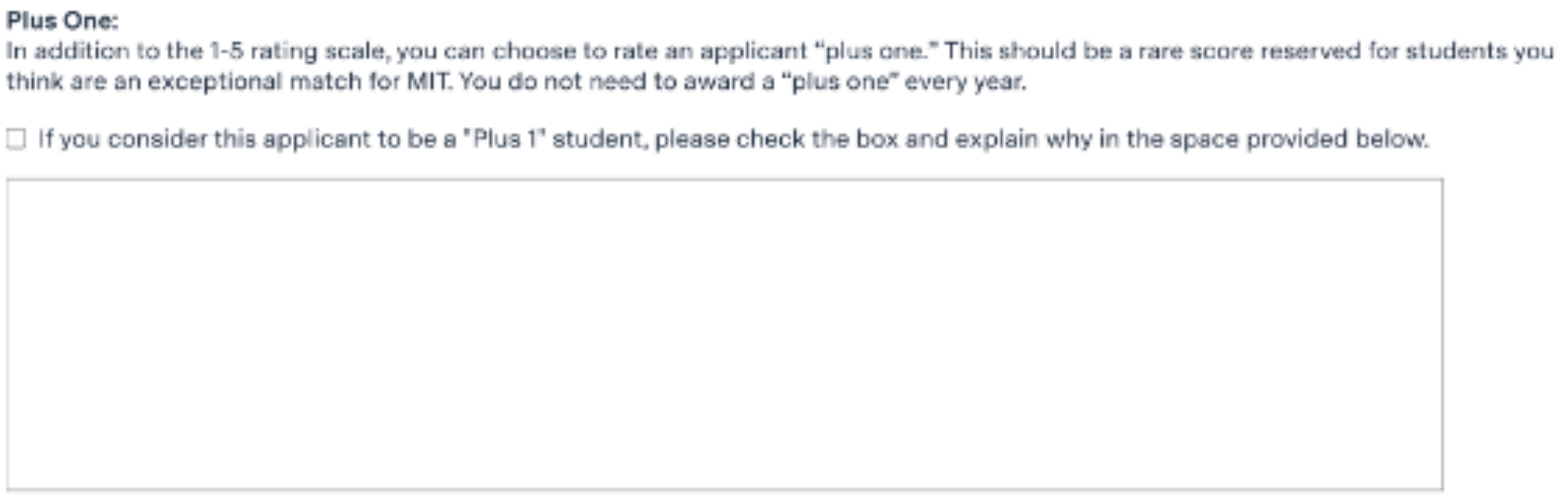
How would you rate this applicant overall?

- ○ 5 - Exceptional
- ○ 4 - Outstanding
- ○ 3 - Solid
- ○ 2 - Below average
- ○ 1 - Not Recommended

Rating the Applicant

Important Notes

- Many applicants are exceptional → **use the full scale**. 3 or 4 is **not** a bad rating.
- **Consider context:** family background, school community, personal challenges, and what makes their achievement meaningful.
- **Plus One:** In addition to the 1-5 rating scale, you can choose to rate a applicant "plus one." This should be a **rare** score reserved for students you think are an exceptional match for MIT. **You do not need to award a "plus one" every year.**



Interview Report Guidelines

Format & Structure

- Style: Narrative, not a transcript of the interview
- Length: 4-6 paragraphs
  - **Interview that go more in-depth will likely yield longer reports**
- To make the review of the report easier, put an extra line between paragraphs

Optional Structures

- By topic (e.g. academics, hobbies, future plans)
- By key traits (e.g. leadership, initiative)
- By rating categories (e.g. engagement, personal qualities)

Interview Report Guidelines

- Describe your familiarity (or lack thereof) with the student's school, the community.
- Support your summary view of the student by using examples from the conversation
- Detail the aspects that **sparked the student's enthusiasm**. Where did their **personal qualities** stand out? Explain why they are a good match.
- Motivation and Context – Explain **why** the student made certain choices. This will help us understand their circumstances.
- Show not tell

Interview Report Guidelines

Writing a Difficult Report

Occasionally, you might have trouble writing an interview report because the student was quiet or you didn't "click." In these cases:

- Describe your efforts to **connect**
- **Be factual**: "gave one-word answers" is better than just "nervous"
- If needed, write:
  - "*Based on my conversation with this student, I don't feel that I have gained enough information to write a full narrative. I've included brief notes below.*"
- **This type of interviews is rare**

After the Interviews

Decisions

- ECs will receive and email from **Admissions Office** with the EA/RA decision dates
- After a student has viewed their decision, it will be made available to you **the next day** on the Interview tab of the EC portal [assuming the student checked first]
- **You are welcome to reach out to admitted students to offer your congratulations!**
- **Please do not reach out to deferred or denied applicants.** If these students reach out, you should direct them to our website or admissions, where we'll have specific blogs for these applicants.

Help with Admitted Student Gatherings

Wait List

- Each year Admissions determines if there is space to admit students off the waitlist.
- Once a decision is made **(usually by mid to late-May)**, we will **notify ECs via email** with an update.

Low Acceptance Rate

- Most students you interview will be very good applicants, and most will be denied.
  - With very high yield rece, we can only admit very few students to target ~1100 enrolled students
- There are other reasons to interview, even if none of you applicants get admitted
  - Engaging with young generations
  - Share your love for MIT and using STEM to improve the world
  - Meet applicants from local community or other parts of the world
  - Inspire students to continue working hard (not everyone has to attend MIT)